

The Cycle of 'Lawfare'

REVIEW

WSJ

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL WEEKEND

The 1950s Ranch House, Reborn

OFF DUTY

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Investigators at the SEC** have recently probed Chicago-based startup Dream Exchange and its ties to the Church of Scientology. **B9**

◆ **BlackRock's new AI** infrastructure consortium is close to an agreement to acquire Aligned Data Centers for about \$20 billion. **B9**

◆ **AI Startup Groq** aims to establish more than a dozen data centers next year. **B9**

◆ **Clariant, the Swiss** chemical company, said it rejected claims in lawsuits filed by BP and Exxon Mobil that its purchases of ethylene broke EU competition law. **B10**

◆ **Shares of Beauty Tech** Group, owner of LED light therapy mask CurrentBody, rose 6.3% after it started conditional trading on the London Stock Exchange. **B10**

◆ **Princes Group**, the canned-tuna and ready-meals company, plans to list on the London Stock Exchange. **B10**

◆ **Economic activity** among U.S. services firms was unchanged last month, an unexpected result hurt by a pullback in business and weaker employment. **A2**

◆ **The S&P 500** added less than 0.1% on Friday, reaching its third-straight record close, while the Dow rose 0.5% and the Nasdaq slipped 0.3%. **B10**

World-Wide

◆ **Hamas said it was ready** to release the remaining hostages in Gaza as long as certain conditions of a broader peace agreement were met, offering no clear position on other elements of President Trump's 20-point peace plan. **A1**

◆ **Trump ordered another** lethal military strike on an alleged drug-trafficking boat in the Caribbean, escalating his campaign after declaring this past week in a confidential notice to Congress that the U.S. is in an armed conflict with the drug cartels. **A1**

◆ **Senate Democrats again** blocked Republicans' seven-week stopgap spending bill, effectively guaranteeing the government shutdown will stretch into next week. **A6**

◆ **Supreme Court granted** the Trump administration's request to lift temporary legal protections for Venezuelans living in the U.S. **A3**

◆ **A federal judge sentenced** Sean "Diddy" Combs to just over four years in prison for his conviction on prostitution offenses. **A3**

◆ **One of those killed** and one injured in Thursday's terrorist attack in Manchester were hit by gunfire from police trying to stop the attacker from entering a synagogue. **A7**

◆ **Apple blocked apps** that enable users to track ICE agents after pressure from the Justice Department. **A4**

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The embarrassing Pete Hegseth **A15**

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Swift's 'Life of a Showgirl' Opens Dramatically



MAKING A SCENE: Fans of Taylor Swift react at an event for the pop idol's latest album, 'The Life of a Showgirl,' at the Astor Theater in Melbourne, Australia, on Friday. Across the world, AMC theaters were showing a movie tied to the release.

L.A.'s Entertainment Economy Looks Like a Disaster Movie

By BEN FRITZ

LOS ANGELES—Brian Mainolfi has been drawing since he came to this city in 1994. The Baltimore native started as an assistant to legendary Looney Tunes animator Chuck Jones, worked on Disney's "The Hunchback of Notre Dame" and "Mulan," and spent a decade on the animated sitcom "American Dad."

The appeal of the work was simple. "People love cartoons,"

he said. "And I love making cartoons."

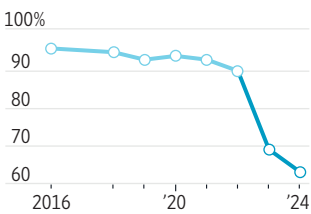
Since his last show was canceled in 2024, Mainolfi's artistic output has been limited to dinosaurs and monsters in his sketchbook. Like thousands of people who work in the entertainment industry, he has become collateral damage of a precipitous slowdown in production. The only work he's found is teaching an animation class at a Cal State campus three hours away, for \$350 a

week.

Mainolfi's family of four never lived extravagantly on his salary of around \$100,000, but now they're using retirement and college savings and scrimping to survive in their three-bedroom ranch house in suburban Burbank. With his union healthcare set to disappear at the end of the year for lack of work, the 54-year-old is trying to figure out for the first time in his life what he could

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Occupancy rate of sound stages for studio productions in greater Los Angeles



Note: No data reported for 2017
Note: Hollywood actors and writers were on strike for much of 2023.
Source: FilmLA and studio participants

President Escalates Campaign Of Boat Strikes

By LARA SELIGMAN AND VERA BERGENGRUEN

President Trump ordered another lethal military strike on an alleged drug-trafficking boat in the Caribbean early Friday, escalating his campaign after declaring this past week in a confidential notice to Congress that the U.S. is in an armed conflict with the drug cartels.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said on social-media post that on Trump's orders he had directed a "lethal, kinetic strike on a narco-trafficking vessel" in the U.S. Southern Command region early Friday. The strike was conducted in international waters just off the coast of Venezuela and killed four men aboard, Hegseth wrote.

This was at least the fourth such strike in the Trump administration's expanding crackdown on what it says are Latin America-based drug gangs, and it brought the death toll from the strikes to at least 21. The administration is facing mounting questions from lawmakers on both sides of the aisle about whether the military strikes are legal.

The boat struck Friday was affiliated with "Designated Terrorist Organizations," Heg-

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EXCHANGE



MILAN'S MOMENT

Come for an aperitivo, stay for the tax breaks **B1**

Shutdown Lays Bare Crisis Of Trust in U.S. Institutions

By DAMIAN PALETTA

Between 2013 and 2019, three government shutdowns were caused by Sen. Ted Cruz's stand against the Affordable Care Act, Sen. Chuck Schumer's push on children of immigrants and President Trump's demand for border wall money.

The 2025 shutdown is about something deeper: a complete breakdown in trust.

Democrats don't trust that the White House will take any spending agreement and adhere to it. The White House has for months routinely ig-

nored congressional appropriations, keeping government funds from flowing as directed by Congress.

Trump, twice-impeached by Democrats during his first term and having survived two assassination attempts while out of office, doesn't appear to trust the minority party on virtually anything. He has run his second term by uniparty rule, through narrowly passed Republican legislation and a record-shattering number of executive orders.

That's left little hope for the trust needed to negotiate a deal. Office of Management

and Budget Director Russell Vought has already moved to cancel billions of dollars in congressionally appropriated money. On Friday, Vought said he was freezing \$2.1 billion in funds for Chicago.

"I was just trying to figure out a process we could create that will first create trust," Sen. Ruben Gallego (D., Ariz.) said of a failed attempt to broker talks.

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R., S.D.), meanwhile, suggested that trust

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◆ **The GOP's spending bill is blocked in the Senate.... A6**

Hell Hath No Fury Like a Coffee Drinker in 2025

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Prices are driving people to expletive-laden rants, but few are quitting caffeine

By RACHEL LOUISE ENSIGN

Coffee drinkers are steamed.

Roasted coffee prices at the grocery store are up 22% in the past year, more than any other item tracked by the government. Prices at some coffee shops are going up too. \$10 latte, anyone?

Lots of things are more expensive, but coffee isn't like cereal or chicken. The daily fix is

all that's keeping millions from a throbbing headache and foul mood. So while people may wince at the price, they're buying it anyway—and reserving the right to rant.

Social media is filled with expletive-laden diatribes from the coffee aisle. One TikTok user posted footage of \$17.49 tubs of Folgers at Costco

set to the DMX lyric "y'all gon' make me lose my mind" (The

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Pfizer's Pricing Deal Went Down to the Wire

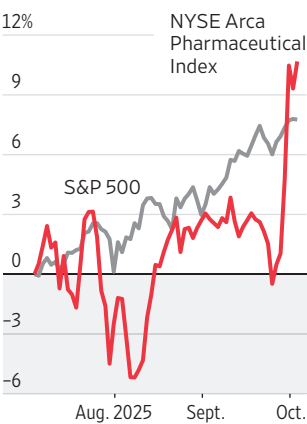
Over a weekend in late September, the team of Pfizer officials working with the Trump administration on drug prices got a message: Clear your schedules.

By Liz Essley Whyte, Jonathan D. Rockoff and Peter Loftus

Negotiations were reaching a tipping point. CEO Albert Bourla and Chris Klomp, head of Medicare, who was leading negotiations for the administration, had met in Washington and reached a handshake agreement on the contours of

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Index performance, past three months



Source: FactSet

